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## 7. Theological and Methodological Evaluation

Having examined in depth the perspectives on the death of Christ held by Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama, we now proceed in this chapter with a discussion of some pertinent theological and methodological issues related to this study. We begin by answering the research questions that were formulated in the first chapter. Although many of the issues that these questions were designed to address have already been discussed at length in the course of our presentation on each of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama, it is helpful to summarize the key points in an organized manner. After working through the research questions, we will address three interrelated theological concerns that have surfaced from this research study. The first relates to the theological problem of divine impassibility. The reason for this discussion is that the idea that God can suffer is implicitly assumed by Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama – and not only by them, but by many, if not most, non-Western Christians. Next, we will also examine, albeit briefly, the alleged relationship between the sacrifice motif in the Cross and perpetuation of violence in the world, a concern which is raised by Koyama, and perhaps also one which is implicit in Endō. The third issue is the problem of eternal damnation – a stumbling block for many Japanese people. Following these discussions, we will then raise some pertinent questions from our research on the important subject of theological methodology. The chapter ends with a consideration of some principles for doing theology in a cross-cultural context.

### Research Questions Revisited

*RQ 1. What is the nature and significance of the death of Christ in the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama? What are the similarities and differences between the three views?*

Kitamori and Koyama stand in the historic tradition of the Church, and particularly that of the Reformation, in their affirmation of the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ as the defining centrality of the Christian faith. Endō, despite his lifelong ambivalence toward the Catholic faith which he felt compelled to believe in because of his mother, could still be interpreted as viewing the Cross as an important symbol of Christianity. However, he locates its significance not in the theological sense of its efficacy in redeeming sinful

humanity from sin and eternal punishment, but rather in what he believes to be the supreme display of Christ's full identification with suffering humanity. In this sense, Endō can still be located within Christian tradition. However, it is noted that he does not attach any importance to the historicity of the Resurrection, for he believes that its true meaning lies symbolically in the experience of the abiding companionship of the crucified Christ in the hearts of his disciples. Kitamori and Koyama, on the other hand, subscribe to the teaching that the Cross is God's historic and historical means of redeeming fallen humanity and reconciling men and women to himself. In any case, all three thinkers show less interest in *how* the Cross actually saves – for that is ultimately unknowable – than in what it reveals about God's nature. Such theological posture brings to mind Takakura Tokutarō, a Japanese theologian of an earlier generation, who said that “we are not saved by an atonement theory [... but] only by Christ's Cross” (cited in Jennings, 2005: 334).<sup>1</sup>

For Kitamori, the Cross reveals a God who experiences intense pain as he puts to death his own Son in order to save sinful humanity. Divine pain, according to Kitamori, is generated when God, in his intentional embrace of those who have become his enemies because of their betrayal of his love, overcomes his wrath against them with his love for them. Indeed, the brutal death of the Son of God on the Cross is indicative of the pain of the Father as he embraces sinful humanity. In other words, God's love is a suffering love. In sum, Christ suffered *because of* sinful humanity, hence the pain of God; and he suffered *for* sinful men and women, thereby reconciling them to God.

Koyama adopts an essentially similar perspective, positing a suffering God who embraces and confronts sinful humanity through the death of Christ. However, Koyama does not make pain a divine attribute, and hence finds himself free from all the theological knots that entangle Kitamori. Divine pain, for Koyama, is neither an ontological nor a cosmological concept, but an intensely historical one. That being said, Koyama's overriding concern is really not so much with the theology of the Cross – important as that is – but with its ethical and missiological implications. For him, the Cross reveals an impassioned God who continually moves toward the periphery in search of that one lost sheep. The Church therefore must do the same, putting on the crucified mind of Christ as she ministers to transform the world into the image of Christ.

In contrast to Kitamori's God who acts in wrath and in love, and Koyama's God who confronts and embraces at the same time, Endō's God knows no wrath and hence does not confront. God, according to Endō, is like a suffering mother who only knows how to love and embrace completely.

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<sup>1</sup> The great Scottish novelist George MacDonald similarly insists that Christians must place their faith in the atoning Christ and not in any theory of the Atonement (1885: 91). Takakura could have been influenced by MacDonald, having spent about nine months at New College, Edinburgh, from June 1921.

This fundamental difference between Kitamori and Koyama on one side and Endō on the other can be explained by their views on sin and suffering. While the former commit to the teaching that Christ suffered for the sins of the world, Endō takes the view that Christ suffered in order to share in the world's sufferings. Indeed, Endō would go so far as to project onto Christ all human suffering, making the Incarnation, and particularly the Passion narrative, the paschal mirror of the sufferings of the world. It is clear that, for Endō, the existential human problem addressed by the Cross is suffering, whereas for Kitamori and Koyama, it is sin. While sin is defined by Kitamori primarily as the betrayal of God's love, and by Koyama concretely as idolatry, dehumanization, and ecological damage, the idea is vague, almost absent, in Endō. Indeed, whatever little he has to say about sin is discussed in terms of moral failure. The lack of theological understanding of sin in Endō explains why he sees the death of Christ as exemplary suffering rather than as atonement.

In Endō's reckoning, the problem of suffering is not resolved by its removal; that would be impossible since suffering is an integral part of human experience. Rather, it is through suffering that one experiences the love of Christ, the eternal companion who understands suffering since he has participated in it. In other words, Christ suffered *like* all suffering humans. It is this experience of love that gives human life its existential meaning. Indeed, Koyama appreciates Endō's perspective for what he calls the "Immanuel factor" (personal communication).

Kitamori, on the other hand, is largely silent about human suffering, not unexpectedly since his full occupation is with the pain of God. He does talk about human pain, but sees it as fulfilling the singular function of serving or testifying to the pain of God. Koyama's view is the most balanced of the three. He views suffering as an inevitable consequence of sin. The sins of idolatry (against God), dehumanization (against one's fellow human beings), and ecological damage (against God's creation) create boomerang effects of suffering. In this sense, Koyama may be thought of as being a bridge between Kitamori and Endō. The Cross, for Koyama then, not only pronounces God's decisive judgment against sin, but also addresses the problem of suffering through the suffering of Christ.

In sum, we see that Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama are less interested in the classical debates in Western theology on the Atonement with regard to its nature, extent, and necessity. It is not that they see these as unimportant, but they focus their primary interest not on abstract theories but on the divine demeanor revealed through the incarnated life and ultimately the death of Christ. Although the theological details are different, the three men share a common understanding of the death of Christ as the supreme demonstration of the suffering love of God. It is this suffering love of the impassioned God that makes the Cross existentially meaningful for all humanity.

*RQ 2. To what extent do the views of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama reflect the perspectives on the Cross in Scripture?*

Kitamori and Koyama are to be commended for their unflinching commitment to the whole biblical text as the Word of God. Their writings are permeated with Scriptural quotations. Their love for the Old Testament is especially evident. Both men believe that the Bible speaks of a God of pathos, a God who is intensely involved in the experiences of human history. The revelation of God as he is first known through the pages of the Old Testament reaches its fullness in Jesus Christ, the incarnated Son of God. Endō, in contrast, has little use of the Old Testament, believing that it paints a wrathful deity completely different from the God described in the Gospels. He hardly ventures into the rest of the New Testament beyond the four Gospels, preferring to set his focus singularly on the nature of God as he is revealed through the life and death of Christ. For his interpretation of the Gospels, Endō employs Bultmann's hermeneutic of demythologization, and comes to the conclusion that many, if not most of, Jesus' sayings were concocted by the disciples after the event of the Cross in order to present what they had come to understand as the "truth" about Christ as the eternal companion of suffering people everywhere. Needless to say, the miracles are also weeded out altogether, not because they are thought to be incompatible with modern science, but because they do not contribute to Endō's preconceived image of Jesus as a person who is ultimately ineffectual.

Of course, Endō's view of the Cross as the supreme symbol of identification with suffering humanity and his portrayal of the "risen" Christ as eternal companion cannot be said to be unbiblical. On the contrary, these are powerful biblical themes. The problem, however, arises when these are the *only* themes that define Endō's theology of the Cross. The idea that the Cross truly and objectively achieves the redemption of sinful humanity is completely absent. Any theory which contains some truths and yet asserts itself as complete could often be more theologically dangerous than a theory which is completely wrong.

Kitamori and Koyama acknowledge the multiple images that the Bible uses in its presentation of the atoning event of the Cross. They are also aware of the fact that the Bible does not contain any Atonement theory: it simply states that Jesus died for sinful humanity without saying exactly how. Kitamori and Koyama therefore do not develop any of the images directly related to the mechanics of the Cross. As mentioned earlier, their focus is on divine pathos, a theme that both men developed first from the Old Testament, Jeremiah 31:20 for Kitamori, and Hosea 11:8 for Koyama. According to Kitamori, the impassioned God possesses the capacity to experience pain, and he did experience that pain when he saw his Son die on the Cross. Koyama understands that the earth-shaking event of the Cross provides nothing less than an irrefutable testimony of an impassioned God who suffers for humanity. Interestingly, both men cite the Parable of the Prodigal Son to prove their point about the impassioned Father.

If there is one biblical theme that is shared commonly by Kitamori, Koyama, and Endō in their perspectives on the death of Christ, it must be that of divine love. All three affirm that it is the principal attribute of love that compels God to willingly choose the path of great suffering for the sake of all humanity. According to Kitamori, divine love generates pain within God because, as God, he is also deeply committed to justice. But divine love triumphs over divine wrath because, while both are part of God's nature, the former is his primary attribute while the latter is understood as secondary to his nature. Koyama shares a somewhat similar view, maintaining that the meaning of Christ's sacrifice must be understood in the larger contextual reality of God's love.

*RQ 3. To what extent do the views of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama reflect the perspectives on the Cross within classical Christian theology?*

It is hard to compare the views of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama with classical theories of the Atonement since it was never the intention of any of these three men to construct a theory to explain how the Cross saves people. Kitamori, as we have seen, judges all Atonement theories which do not take into account God's pathos as deficient. He subscribes to the view of the magisterial Reformers that the death of Christ is both penal and substitutionary, believing that, since this theory possesses the intensity of divine passion, it best represents the biblical account of the Cross. We have also suggested that despite Kitamori's theological confession, it is more accurate to describe his *theologia crucis* as a *Dolor Dei* "model" of the Atonement, comprising the objective dimension of penal substitution and the subjective element of divine pain when God, within himself, struggles to overcome wrath with love. The triumph of God's love at the Cross recalls God's triumph over his enemies in Aulén's theory – only in the case of Kitamori, it is the triumph of divine love over divine wrath. This battle is certainly no less intense in Kitamori than it is in Aulén.

Koyama does not align himself with a particular Atonement theory. However, he derives theological validation from Luther's parallel concepts of *opus alienum* and *opus proprium* to suggest that God confronts sinful humans on the cross in order to embrace them. The Christian's faith then must be modeled after Christ whose cry of dereliction using the lament of Psalms 22:1 is a demonstration of ultimate faith, *ad Deum contra Deum confugere*. In this sense, Koyama relates the divine demeanor of Christ on the cross to the First Commandment, the message of which is "[t]o believe in, to hope in, to love and to fear God (*credere, sperare, diligere, timere deum*) at all times" (1985: 246; so Luther). The firm understanding that Koyama has of the confrontation of God as *opus alienum* and the embrace of God as *opus proprium* leads him to conclude that divine wrath as a motif of the Atonement is subservient to that of divine love, and that therefore the sacrifice of Christ is not to be interpreted as a means to placate God's wrath or satisfy God's justice (1995: 268).

Two points are in order here. First, Koyama appropriates Luther's *opus alienum* and *opus proprium* with a nuance that is different from Luther's original intention. Let us recall that Luther first introduces the concepts in his explanation of the sixteenth thesis of the Heidelberg Disputation:

[W]hen sin is recognized grace is sought and obtained. Thus to those who are humble after this fashion God gives grace, and he who is humbled is exalted. The law humbles us, grace exalts us. The law works fear and wrath, grace works hope and mercy. Through the law comes knowledge of sin. Through the knowledge of sin comes humility, and through humility grace is acquired. In this way, when God makes a man a sinner that he may make him righteous, God is bringing in his strange work [*opus alienum*] that he may in the end bring in his proper work [*opus proprium*]. (Luther, 1962b: 289)

Alister McGrath interprets *opus alienum* in the last line of Luther's explanation either "as *passiones Christi* or human *Anfechtung*," and suggests that whichever it is, Luther understands its ultimate source to be God (1990: 151). Horst Beintker understands *opus alienum* as the latter; it is a "strange work" because "God assaults man in order to break him down and thus to justify him" (McGrath, 1990: 151).<sup>2</sup> In either case, the point is that God uses a totally unexpected means to bring about his desired ends, namely, the salvation of sinners. This is why the Cross is "foolishness" to the wise (cf. 1 Cor. 1:18).

The second point relates to Koyama's comment in his later life that the theology of the Cross is "a doctrine of love, not of sacrifice" (1997b: 59). While it is undeniable that God's mercy lies latent beneath his wrath, it is presumptuous to dismiss sacrifice as an important soteriological theme. Luther's bifurcation of the work of God into *opus proprium* and *opus alienum* does not in any way compromise the sacrificial element in the Atonement. On the contrary it presupposes that Christ bore divine punishment (*opus alienum*) on the cross, and through his sacrificial death secured forgiveness for humankind (*opus proprium*). If Christ's sacrifice does not in effect satisfy God's wrath, there can be no objective possibility of forgiveness even if it is a full demonstration of love. Moreover, Luther's dictum *ad Deum contra Deum confugere* makes sense only in the context where divine love and divine wrath are simultaneously operative, even if the latter is considered penultimate to the former. Indeed, as we have seen in chapter 2, the apostle Paul consistently treats the death of Christ as propitiatory, that is, it appeases God's wrath against sin (cf. Rom. 3:25; 5:9; Eph. 1:7; 2:13; Col. 1:20). Therefore, instead of driving a wedge between love and sacrifice, one could say that, on the Cross, God demonstrated his *real* love through a *real* sacrifice. In this sense, Kitamori is closer to the biblical witness

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<sup>2</sup> McGrath also points out that, similarly, Luther understands the devil as "God's instrument, who performs the *opus alienum Dei* on his behalf in order that the *opus proprium* may be realized" (1990: 151).

when he posits the Cross as the site where divine love and divine wrath are united.

Endō's understanding that Christ died in order to share his love with humans by identifying with their sufferings comes close to Abelard's moral influence theory. Just as Christ's first disciples were profoundly moved and transformed by his utter selflessness and embracing love, and in the process experienced his eternal companionship in their hearts, so would men and women today should they come into encounter with him in their religious circumstances, in the way that Endō did. As we have seen, Endō in his later life believes that God will reveal himself differently, but no less truly, in other religions and through other religious experiences. This is, of course, a radical departure from classical Christian doctrine.

*RQ 4. To what extent do the views of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama reflect themes and values generally identified with Japanese culture and religion?*

Anyone who expects to read exotic theology from Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama will be sorely disappointed. While it is true that their writings are a function of their particular understanding of Scripture mediated through their socio-cultural settings and personal life experiences, the premise of anthropological universality and the common text of the Bible do in effect set the parameters for their theological reflection so that their perspectives are never so novel to the extent of being completely unintelligible to a person from another society or culture. Yet culture does exert a profound influence on the way one interprets the Bible, so much so that in order to engage in the theological task, one need to understand language, cultural symbols and their meanings. Conversely, one can therefore expect theological insights to be nuanced differently from culture to culture. The writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama do indeed reflect some common values that can be identified with Japanese culture and religion. We will now examine three common themes that have surfaced from their works: self-negation, suffering, and universal embrace.

The concept of self-negation is inherent in the religious consciousness of people in South and East Asia where the cultural worldview<sup>3</sup> is shaped by monism (e.g. Hinduism) or pantheism (e.g. Taoism and Shinto). It is not that there is no sense of the existence of the individual self among these people; rather the self constantly and instinctively negates all individualizing tendencies and submerges itself in what Indologist Nakamura Hajime calls the "Universal Self" (1964: 99).<sup>4</sup> The influence of Buddhism on China and Japan is, of course,

<sup>3</sup> The worldview concept is, admittedly, not an unproblematic one. For the purpose of our discussion, however, we use Paul Hiebert's definition of worldview as "the fundamental cognitive, affective, and evaluative assumptions and frameworks a people make about the nature of reality which they use to order their lives" (2003: 15).

<sup>4</sup> Although Nakamura uses the term "Universal Self" to refer specifically to the Indian view of life, the idea is applicable to Chinese and Japanese cultures as well.

seminal, and the Buddhist teaching of *nirvana* as the ultimate negation of the self finds a ready reception in these two cultures. The meontological approach to philosophy characteristic of the Eastern sages testifies to the centrality of the principle of negation.

In Japan, the philosophical idea of self-negation finds concrete expression in such cultural values as harmony (*wa* 和) and modesty (*kenkyo* 謙虚), and in the aesthetic qualities of simplicity and austerity (*wabi-sabi* 侘び 寂び). So, for instance, self-effacement is highly regarded as good moral behavior. Young children are taught that the description *iiko* (“good boy” or “good girl”) is very often modified by the adjective *sunao na*, which means “gentle, mild, meek, obedient, submissive, docile, compliant, yielding” (Davies and Ikeno, 2002: 147). Hence, to be called *sunao na iiko* 素直な良い子 is extremely complimentary for any child. In the arts, there is the classic example of the *haiku*, the traditional form of Japanese poetry that makes use of only seventeen syllables. Japanese people find beauty in the “artistic asceticism” of the *haiku* (Takenaka, 1986: 76). Of course, in *bushidō* 武士道, the code of the samurai, the ultimate honorable act of self-negation is to commit ritual suicide.

The principle of self-negation is evident in the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama. For Kitamori, the pain of God is the result of divine negation. For Endō, it is the ineffectual and powerless Christ who models self-negation. And Koyama locates divine negation in the self-denial of Christ which ultimately leads him to the cross. The crucified mind of Christ and the “painful helplessness” of God in human history reflect “the depth of biblical grace and ethics” (Koyama, 1985: 125). The self-negating character of God is revealed through this Christ who saved others but refused to save himself (Koyama, 1985: 260; cf. Mk. 15, 31). In sum, all three men, because of their cultural disposition, find themselves completely amenable to the idea of the kenotic Christ. This is why Kitamori and Koyama find such strong affinity with Luther’s rejection of the theology of glory in favor of a theology of the Cross which always stands on the “outside,” in the periphery (Kitamori, 1986: 12; Koyama, 1985: 255). Endō, unfortunately, stretches the idea of the kenosis to the extreme, such that Christ is completely devoid of his divine power.

Second, we find suffering presenting itself as a key theme in all three’s writings. In all probability this has to do with the Buddhist understanding of suffering as the existential human reality. The suffering mentality of the Japanese has led to the cultivation of the virtues of endurance (*gaman* 我慢) and perseverance (*gambari* 頑張り). In other words, rather than fleeing suffering, Japanese people are schooled to face it with fortitude, either by waiting it out patiently, or if possible, by working determinedly to overcome it.<sup>5</sup>

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<sup>5</sup> It is no exaggeration to say that it is the spirit of *gaman* and *gambari* that motivated Japan to overcome suffering and transform the country from the ashes of war into a modern economic powerhouse within a single generation.

In the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama, we see the motif of patient suffering projected onto God. In other words, they all assume without qualification that God can suffer, hence the emphasis on the pain of God in Kitamori and the suffering love of God in the writings of the other two. That God can suffer poses no theological difficulty to them. Endō and Koyama are also concerned about human suffering, but find salvation possible because of the capacity of God to suffer for and with humanity. Kitamori acknowledges the reality of human pain, but suggests that its resolution is to be found in its willingness to be used to witness to divine pain. Since some Christians find offensive the idea that God can suffer, we shall discuss the theological problem of the impassibility of God in the next section.

The third common theme in the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama that appears to be culturally motivated is the idea of a universal embrace. This idea is related to the Buddhist spirit of benevolence. Nakamura, in his magisterial *Ways of Thinking of Eastern Peoples*, explains:

The Japanese lay special emphasis upon the love of others. Banzan Kumazawa (1619-1691), a famous Confucianist of the Tokugawa period, calls Japan “The land of benevolence.” The love of others in its purified form is named “benevolence.” [...] This idea was introduced into Japan with the advent of Buddhism. Among many sects of Japanese Buddhism, the Pure Land Buddhism (Jōdo sect), a religion which typically emphasizes benevolence, enjoys great popularity. The Pure Land Buddhism preaches the benevolence of Amitābha Buddha who saves the bad man as well as the ordinary man. (1964: 381)

It is no coincidence that many Japanese see the parallel between the mercy of Amitābha Buddha and the grace of the Christian God. This may explain the fond use of the word “embrace” to describe the saving act of God. Kitamori, for instance, employs the words *daku* 抱く (embrace) and *tsutsumu* 包む (enfold) frequently to describe God’s love in action toward his enemies.<sup>6</sup> Koyama too describes the cross as the site where God not only confronts sinners but ultimately embraces them. Moreover, he juxtaposes the image of the self-negating God with the metaphor of divine embrace when he suggests that the crucified Christ embraces humanity by choosing not to save himself (1985: 260). And of course, the Jesus that Endō portrays is full of love and embraces all whom he encounters, especially those who suffer at the margins of society. Toward the end of *Deep River*, Endō expresses his pluralist religious vision through the words of Mitsuko about a “deep river of humanity” which “embraces” (*daku* 抱く) people and carries them away (1994: 342). As mentioned earlier, Endō’s religion does not confront but only embraces.

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<sup>6</sup> The metaphor of “embrace” is used by Miroslav Volf for his work *Exclusion and Embrace: A Theological Exploration of Identity, Otherness, and Reconciliation* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1996). Volf readily admits that the metaphor is a culturally conditioned one, that is, it will work in some cultures but not others (Volf, 1996: 29).

Even though Kitamori and Koyama talk about divine confrontation besides divine embrace, it is clear that for them, the latter is the ultimate divine act that subsumes the former. Moreover, it seems that all three men seem to posit the idea of a universal embrace. In other words, no one is excluded from the embrace of God. It is clear that Endō believed in universal salvation, especially toward the end of his life, but it is harder to conclude the same for Kitamori and Koyama. One could imagine them professing agnosticism on whether all people will be finally saved. However, even if they do not believe in universal salvation, one can certainly make a case to say that they understand Christ's death provides universal redemption.<sup>7</sup>

It is instructive to note that all three writers are silent on the subject of hell. It is a difficult subject, to be sure, but one which is important to Christian doctrine. While one needs to exercise caution not to draw any definitive conclusion by arguing from silence, one could perhaps say that the cultural sensibilities of these three men cause them to steer clear from this topic. Nakamura, citing Anezaki Masaharu, calls the Christian teaching on hell "the outstanding line of demarcation between Christianity and Buddhism" (1964: 384).

For the Japanese, full of the spirit of tolerance, *eternal damnation* is absolutely inconceivable. A Catholic priest, who forsook Christianity under the persecution of the Tokugawa Government, condemned the idea of eternal damnation preached in Christianity. He said, regarding reward and punishment in the other world, if God be the Lord of Benevolence, he ought to condemn Himself rather than condemn and punish His creatures for their sins. Among the doctrines of Christianity the idea of eternal damnation was especially hard for the Japanese to understand. This also reveals one of the characteristic ideas long held by the Japanese.

The idea of "being beyond deliverance forever" was also hard for the Japanese to comprehend [...]. The idea of discriminating predispositions to salvation, like the idea of eternal damnation, was not generally accepted by the Japanese Buddhists. Generally accepted, instead, was the view, "All men are predisposed to become Buddhists." (Nakamura, 1964: 384-85, emphasis in text)<sup>8</sup>

The difficulty on the part of the Japanese to comprehend eternal condemnation is in all probability related to the fact that they find the idea of exclusion repugnant. Perhaps this is not surprising in a highly communitarian

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<sup>7</sup> Universal salvation presupposes universal redemption, but the converse relationship is not a necessary one. That is, Christ died for *all* humanity, but this does not mean that all will be saved. In classical Reformed teaching, however, the argument is made that since nothing that the sovereign God wills to do can fail to actualize, Christ could not possibly have died for all because the biblical record is clear that there will be some who will not be saved. Five-point Calvinism therefore affirms limited atonement. See Murray (1962: 27-31); Packer (1974: 37-39); and of course, John Owen's 1648 classic treatise *The Death of Death in the Death of Christ*, especially Chapters I-III of Book III (1959: 124-49).

<sup>8</sup> I am indebted to Dr. Harold Netland for directing me to this reference.

society like Japan where the experience of being excluded from one's group is highly stressful and distressing. In such a cultural context, one can see why Koyama's notion of the cosmological embrace is so appealing. In any case, Nakamura's comment above sheds light on Endō's conception of the maternal God who neither confronts nor condemns but embraces indiscriminately, and perhaps even on the silence on the part of Kitamori and Koyama on matters concerning the eternal destiny of human beings.

In any case, the point is clear: the subject of hell poses a huge challenge to evangelizing a people who are conditioned to believe in an all-embracing benevolence, and hence would reject the idea of hell as fundamentally repulsive. The church in Japan needs to grapple with the issue of divine exclusion, as she takes on the huge challenge of communicating the reality of divine judgment as part of the gospel message. We will pick up the discussion later when we examine the relationship between the Cross and violence later.

*RQ 5. To what extent are the views of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama shaped by their respective biographies?*

It should be clear by now that biography plays a hugely significant role in shaping the respective theological perspectives of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama. Interestingly, all three men possess a penchant for introspection. They all cultivated a love for reading from a young age. Perhaps the social turbulence of the pre-war years and the absence of modern entertainment caused them in their teenage years to turn inward and reflect deeply on their reading in the light of what was happening around them.

In the case of Kitamori, the gift of spiritual sensitivity cultivated in him a sort of Christian mysticism that predisposed him to apprehend biblical truths by intuition (*chokkan* 直感; 1960: 12). The vision he had of the crucified Christ, the numerous close encounters with the deaths of different people in his youth, and his frequent emotional struggles with his own sinfulness recall the experiences of the mystical saints in times past. Kitamori's intuitive nature may also explain his attraction to the philosophy of Nishida, especially the theory of pure experience. Also, the fact that Kitamori never married but devoted his whole life to theological and pastoral work is but a reflection of his singular, monastic-like desire to witness to the pain of God to the Church and to his fellow countrymen and women.

Unlike Kitamori, Endō and Koyama inherited their faith from their families. In the case of Endō, it was an unlikely conversion experience through his baptism which he reluctantly agreed to receive just to please his mother and assuage the pain of her recent divorce. However, he discovered that the sacramental imprint of his baptism on his life was a permanent one; he found it uncomfortable to his cultural identity, yet he could never erase it. Endō's difficult years as a student in France, his recurring illnesses, and his fascination with the turbulent history of the Catholic Church in his own country all

contributed significantly to the shaping of his particular understanding of human religiosity, namely, the quest for love in the midst of suffering.

Koyama's theological understanding is largely shaped by his horrific experiences of the war and his years of overseas service as a missionary and theological educator. The untold suffering caused by the war experienced by both the Japanese as well as the many Asians whom he came into contact with as a result of his ministry in Thailand and Singapore, and the experience of what he perceived to be Western theological imperialism led Koyama to be extremely wary of the evils of a triumphalist ideology in whatever realm, whether in politics, theology, or mission. This is why Koyama finds Abraham's posture of non-insistence in Genesis 13 and the supreme example of Christ's self-denial powerfully illustrative of who God is, and by extension, what Christians should be, living and serving in a world wracked with so much violence and suffering. It is not a wonder that Koyama should always insist that theology must bear fruit through sound ethical and missiological practice.

American novelist and former missionary to Japan, Katherine Paterson, recalls C. S. Lewis when she says "a book cannot be what a writer is not. Who you are informs what you write on a very deep level" (Chattaway, 2007: 65). Our study certainly validates Paterson's comment. The influence of biography on theology is significant, yet one which is not sufficiently acknowledged. The typical scholar working on a particular theologian is often content to provide cursory biographical information as "background" to the "real" discussion of ideas of that theologian, not realizing the full extent of the relationship between one's personal experiences and the way one thinks about the larger issues of life and faith. The autobiographical nature of theology is a subject that certainly merits further examination.<sup>9</sup>

Having surveyed the five research questions pertinent to this discussion, we now move on to the next section where we will discuss the theological problems of divine impassibility, of violence, and of eternal damnation.

### Three Theological Concerns

#### *The Problem of Divine Impassibility*

It is beyond the scope of this work to engage in an in-depth discussion on the theological problem of divine impassibility (*apatheia tou theou*). Nevertheless, it certainly warrants at least a brief treatment since Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama all assume the suffering of God without qualification. We begin by noting that for the major part of the history of the Church, the notion of divine impassibility was taken so much for granted that, until the last half century, it was never really critically examined at all in Western theological circles. In all probability,

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<sup>9</sup> Once again, I am grateful to Dr. Harold Netland for this insight.

*impassibilitas Dei* as a divine attribute came to be accepted as theologically axiomatic after a string of debates over the relations between Father, Son, and Holy Spirit within the divine Godhead in the third century (cf. McWilliams, 1980: 35). Fiercely-committed monotheists such as Praxeas, Epigonus, and Noetus sought to refute the potential heresy of tritheism by emphasizing the identity of the Son with the Father. Such teaching, however, is problematic for its failure to maintain a clear distinction between the persons of the Trinity, and its necessary implication that God the Father suffered and died in the crucifixion of Christ. This view, known as patripassianism, was rigorously refuted by Hippolytus and Tertullian. In their total rejection of patripassianism – and later, theopaschitism, the notion that the whole Godhead suffered on the Cross – some of the early Church Fathers unwittingly applied the Stoic ideal of the human person as one who is in full mastery of one's emotions onto divine personhood. In other words, the divine ideal, postulated as unchanging and unchangeable, was logically extended to include the inability to experience any pain or suffering.<sup>10</sup> The Council of Chalcedon (A.D. 451) condemned as “vain babblings” the idea that God could be subject to suffering (Ngien, 1997: 38). However, because of the Council's primary affirmation of the unity of two natures of Christ “without confusion or change, without division or separation,” some have argued that its adoption of the *theotokos* formula amounts to an implicit admission of divine suffering (Nnamani, 1995: 89).<sup>11</sup>

The concept of divine impassibility as we have it today was actually shaped by Thomas Aquinas. Although Thomas rejected the idea that God can be defined, he utilized the Aristotelian metaphysical understanding of God as the “Unmoved Mover” – the pure being with pure actuality and no potentiality that “moves” all things from a state of potentiality to actuality – to posit a necessary being as the uncaused cause of all things, hence the cosmological argument for the existence of God (see Erickson, 1998: 182-83). Clearly in Thomas' mind, divine immutability implies divine passibility. God's impassability as such is hence understood to mean that God cannot be acted upon or affected emotionally

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<sup>10</sup> The biblical passages that have been used to support divine impassability, such as Numbers 23:19; 1 Samuel 15:29; Psalms 110:4; and Jeremiah 4:28, are therefore the same passages that are used to teach divine immutability. The notions of divine immutability and its doctrinal cousin, divine impassibility (and the later idea of divine simplicity that consequently developed), are in all probability the legacy of neo-Platonism. Netland calls this “another case of culture or the intellectual *zeitgeist* shaping theology” (personal communication). See Feinberg (2001: 233-337) for a masterful critique on the classical understanding of these and other non-moral attributes of God.

<sup>11</sup> There appears to be considerable latitude in the way the Church Fathers understand divine impassibility; there is indeed no uniform consensus among them. For a detailed study, see Amuluche Gregory Nnamani, *The Paradox of a Suffering God: On the Classical, Modern-Western, and Third World Struggles to Harmonise the Incompatible Attributes of the Trinitarian God* (Frankfurt: Peter Lang, 1995), pp. 59-99.

by anything in creation.<sup>12</sup> After Thomas, that God is impassible was simply assumed to be true; and even right through the first half of the twentieth century, theologians by and large maintained a stony silence on the subject (Lee, 1974: 1).<sup>13</sup>

The notion that God cannot suffer, however, has come to be seriously challenged, especially in the last sixty years following the end of the Second World War.<sup>14</sup> The Jewish Holocaust and the atomic catastrophes of Hiroshima and Nagasaki provided disturbing material for theological reconsideration of the infinite opposition (of the early Barth) between God and humans. Christian philosopher Charles Hartshorne fired the first salvo in the theological debate by critiquing Anselm's portrayal of God as a deity who "can give us everything, everything except the right to believe that there is one who, with infinitely subtle and appropriate sensitivity, rejoices in all our joys and sorrows in all our sorrows" (1948: 54).<sup>15</sup> In essence, Hartshorne is asking the question if God could *really* be intelligible to humans if he were "a totally impassive, nonreceptive [*sic*], non-relative being" (Hartshorne, 1948: 54). The metaphysical challenge to divine impassibility was so potent that Daniel Day Williams (1967: 172) could claim that it led to a "structural shift in the Christian mind." It is interesting to note that the groundbreaking work on the Old Testament prophets by the Jewish scholar Abraham Heschel in 1962 probably did more than any other book in helping Christians re-evaluate the notion of the impassible God. In the 1970s, a fresh wave of critiques was launched against the notion of divine impassibility, this time by theologians such as Jürgen Moltmann

<sup>12</sup> J. I. Packer describes the impassable God as a God locked in a "frozen pose" (personal communication).

<sup>13</sup> There are, of course, notable exceptions such as Brasnett (1928) and Robinson (1939).

<sup>14</sup> It was revealed after the war with the publication of his prison letters and papers that Dietrich Bonhoeffer firmly believed in the idea that God suffers. Commenting on what he sees to be the "decisive difference between Christianity and all religions," Bonhoeffer writes, "Man's religiosity makes him look in his distress to the power of God in the world. God is the *deus ex machine*. The Bible directs us to God's powerlessness and suffering; only the suffering God can help" (1971: 361). Bonhoeffer also composes a moving poem entitled *Christen und Heiden* (translated as "Christians and Others" by Conway, 2006: 6), the second stanza of which conveys the same idea with raw potency:

All men go to God in His distress,  
find Him poor, reviled, without shelter or bread,  
watch Him tormented by sin, weakness and death.

Christians stand by God in His hour of grieving. (translated by Conway, 2006)  
Bonhoeffer received his inspiration for this poem from Matthew 26:40. Recalling the point made above on the influence of biography on theology, it would be almost impossible to imagine Bonhoeffer holding fast to the idea of divine impassibility in the context of what he was going through.

<sup>15</sup> See chapter VIII of Anselm's *Proslogium*, in *Saint Anselm: Basic Writings*, trans. S. N. Deane, 2d ed., (La Salle, Ill.: Open Court, 1962), pp. 13-14

(1974), James Cone (1975), and Geddes McGregor (1975). Their point was simple: If we believe that God is actively engaged with humankind, why should we not believe that in his compassion he does indeed share in human suffering?

It appears that the debate whether God can suffer is largely confined within the Western church. Asian Christians, for instance, have always thought the notion of divine impassibility unintuitive and strange (see Lee, 1974; Kwok, 1984). Of course, as we have seen, Kitamori's *Theology of the Pain of God* is one of the earliest and most provocative analyses on the suffering God to come out after the war. Kitamori himself confesses that his goal in publishing the book is to "convert a villainous theology which teaches that God has no pain" (1986: 29). Another seminal work on the subject is that of Korean theologian Jung Young Lee. In a theological *tour de force*, Lee demonstrates from Romans 5:6-10 how the death of Christ is indeed an expression of "the depth of divine empathy," and therefore that the reality of the Cross cannot but nullify the concept of divine impassibility (1974: 57-63). Lee asserts, "The impassible God cannot bear the sins of the world" (Lee, 1961).

Western theologians are more open today to the idea that God can suffer. The seminal writings of Oxford theologian Paul Fiddes in recent years, such as *The Creative Suffering of God* (1998) and *Participating in God* (2000), have made an enormous contribution by clarifying the theological meaning and meaningfulness of divine suffering. Nowadays, it is not uncommon to hear or see in print the expression "God's suffering love" without any qualification (e.g. Volf, 2004: 201). Interestingly, the March theme for "Reflections: Quotations to Stir Heart and Mind," a regular column in *Christianity Today*, is "Suffering God" (Kauffman, 2007: 71). Also, in the brochure entitled *10 Reasons To Believe In A God Who Allows Suffering* published by the theologically-conservative RBC Ministries, the eighth reason cited is that "God suffers with us in our suffering."

No one has suffered more than our Father in heaven. No one has paid more dearly for the allowance of sin into the world. No one has so continuously grieved over the pain of a race gone bad. No one has suffered like the One who paid for our sin in the crucified body of His own Son.

By all accounts, the evidence is that the idea that God can suffer does not pose a huge theological challenge today than it did, say, a generation ago. It remains a theological paradox, especially when the idea is placed in the context of the traditional teaching of God's moral and metaphysical perfection. The Nigerian theologian, Nnamani, argues that the motif of kenosis often used to interpret the idea of divine suffering only makes sense within the framework of a relational ontology that defines the Trinity (1995: 369-403). Thomas Weinandy, a Catholic theologian at Oxford, argues from the presupposition of God as *actus purus* that because God is "immune to suffering" (2000: 154), he suffers only through the humanity of the incarnate Son (Weinandy, 2000: 172-226). Paul Gayrilyuk,

another Catholic theologian teaching at the University of St. Thomas in St. Paul, Minnesota, debunks the common idea that patristic theology limited the suffering of God to the human nature of the Son as a mistaken one, and suggests that the Church Fathers used the notion of divine impassibility in a restricted and nuanced sense “as an *apophatic qualifier* of all divine emotions [...] to rule out those passions and experiences that were unbecoming of the divine nature,” while admitting qualified divine passibility of the Son of God within the framework of the Incarnation without compromising “the irreducible divinity of God” (2004: 16, emphasis in text). According to Gavrilyuk, the way that the Fathers understood divine (im)passibility proved to be effective in countering the Christological heresies of docetism, patripassianism, Arianism, and Nestorianism (Gavrilyuk, 2004: 64-174).

As we can see, the last word on the subject is yet to be spoken. Perhaps this wondrous paradox that “the impassible God suffers” can never be resolved (cf. Weinandy, 2000: 172). That notwithstanding, the suffering love of God has proved to be a helpful concept in pastoral counseling. The reason precisely why we can receive the very real comfort of God in our suffering is that on the cross, God has shown that he does not only understand suffering but that he has experienced the worst of it. We leave this section now, and turn our attention to addressing Koyama’s fear that the motif of sacrifice in the Cross could legitimize the use of violence in a world already wracked by so much violence-induced suffering.

### *The Cross and Violence*

Koyama is not the only one who has expressed reservations about the relationship between the Cross and the (mis)use of violence. In the last fifteen years or so, there have been a growing number of voices decrying the traditional understanding of the Atonement as too gory (e.g. Brown, 1992; Winter, 1995; den Heyer, 1998; Bartlett, 2001; Weaver, 2001). The question has been ably tackled by Mouw (2001), Boersma (2003), and Volf (2004), so that a couple of pertinent points will suffice here. Volf rightly points out that a proper understanding of the Cross “gives no warrant for [any] perpetration of violence” (2004: 20; cf. 1 Pet. 2:21-24). Recounting the violence that Christians had historically committed against Jews and Muslims, Volf laments:

Whenever violence was perpetrated in the name of the cross, the cross was depleted of its “thick” meaning within the larger story of Jesus Christ and “thinned” down to a symbol of religious belonging and power – and the blood of those who did not belong flowed as Christians transmuted themselves from would-be followers of the Crucified to imitators of those who crucified him. (2004: 21)

Volf suggests that the cure against violence “is not less religion, but in a carefully qualified sense, *more* religion” (2004: 17). By this, he means practicing “a stronger and more intelligent commitment to the faith as faith” (Volf, 2004:

17), as Christ's followers imitate the trinitarian God whose life "is characterized by mutually uncoerced and welcomed generosity" (Volf, 2004: 18).

Yet, it is undeniable that the Bible contains violent images that often accompany the salvation narrative. Isaiah 63:1-6, for instance, describes a righteous God "mighty to save," but who accomplishes salvation by trampling his enemies with such wrath that their blood is splattered on his garments. This imagery reminds us of Christ, the conquering Son who dons "a robe dipped in blood" (Rev. 19:3). How are we to make sense of these disturbing images? For a start, these images subvert our domesticated image of God, and remind us that the God of love is also the God of wrath. The Bible is hence unequivocal in its teaching that divine judgment on sin *is* indeed a necessary condition for salvation. This is where the good news comes in. The judgment that is due to sinful humanity is assumed by Christ on the cross. In the eloquent words of Karl Barth, "the Judge delivers Himself to be judged" (1956: 251; cf. 1960: 49). And he does this "for us," that is, "in our place" (Barth, 1956: 251). This is "the good news of Good Friday" (Barth, 1956: 251).

In relation to the thought that Christ died in our place on the cross, John Stott warns against two theological pitfalls. The first is to construe our substitute as Christ *alone*, for that would make him an independent third party intervening between God and humanity; and the second is to speak *only* of God suffering and dying, for that would negate the historical Incarnation and necessary mediation of the Son (Stott, 1986: 156). The right approach is to understand our substitute as "*God in Christ*, who was truly and fully both God and man, and who on that account was uniquely qualified to represent both God and man and to mediate between them" (Stott, 1986: 156). When we think in these terms, we will realize that "[t]he Father did not lay on the Son an ordeal he was reluctant to bear, nor did the Son extract from the Father a salvation he was reluctant to bestow" (Stott, 1986: 151). In other words, although the Cross is a violent event, the Father and the Son are not warring against each other in a divine conflict. On the contrary, as Stott rightly observes, "their wills coincided in the perfect self-sacrifice of love" (Stott, 1986: 152). Indeed, it is hard to justify the use of violence from the Cross when one understands that "[t]he biblical gospel of atonement is of *God satisfying himself by substituting himself for us*" (Stott, 1986: 159-60, emphasis added).

Richard Mouw continues the same line of thought:

The very same God who pours out the divine wrath is the One who experiences the wrathful forsakenness of divine abandonment. God, in the unity of the divine being, is both the violated One and the One who counts that violatedness as satisfying the demands of eternal justice.

In the death on the Cross, God also took our violent impulses upon himself, mysteriously absorbing them into his very being in order to transform them into the power of reconciling love; and then offers that love back to us as a gift of sovereign grace. (2001: 17)

Such is the unfathomable mystery of the Atonement.

“When atonement theories carve out a place for judgement and punishment, do they really legitimate unjust violence?” Hans Boersma asks rhetorically, and then suggests that the opposite might indeed be the case.

By ignoring the judicial meaning of the cross, we convey to victims of violence that their pains and concerns are irrelevant, that they need to “get over it and get on with it.” When punishment has no place at all in our thinking about the cross, sin and evil receive a legitimate and permanent place as an intrinsic part of a world that forever remains out of joint. (2003: 34)

Rather, as Moltmann puts it, on the cross, Christ “identifies God with the victims of violence,” and at the same time identifies “the victim with God, so that they are put under God’s protection and with him are given the rights of which they have been deprived” (1992: 131).

In other words, rather than lending legitimacy to the use of violence, the violence of the Cross is in effect the redemptive last word on violence, for it is the divinely-ordained means of abolishing all the violence and bloodshed in the world (Chua, 2006b: 24). That is, the nature of the violence of the Cross is redemptive, not vindictive. Even so, the use of redemptive violence is solely a divine prerogative. Volf puts it well, “Though imitating God is the height of human holiness, there are things which only God may do. One of them is to deploy violence” (2004: 21). Commenting on the violence that permeates John’s Apocalypse, Volf suggests that in the context of the whole biblical revelation, it is best understood as a “symbolic portrayal of the final exclusion of everything that refuses to be redeemed by God’s suffering love” (Volf, 2004: 21). Volf therefore warns Christians against arrogating for themselves what God has reserved only for himself, to transpose the divine action from the end-time to a time in which God explicitly refrains from deploying violence in order to make repentance possible, and, finally, to transmute a possibility of violence into an actuality (Volf, 2004: 21)

Koyama’s fears are perfectly understandable, but ultimately unfounded. It is true that as a historically-determined religion, Christianity has been extremely violent. Indeed, so-called Christian nations have not been known to exercise the restraint of violence on the global scene. In the light of the gospel of Jesus Christ, who willingly gave his life for the sake of the world’s welfare, it is indeed extremely difficult to justify any use of violence.

### *The Problem of Hell*

Volf makes the insightful observation that the insistence on human non-violence and the divine “prerogative of exercising violence against ‘false prophets’ and ‘beasts’ if they refuse to be redeemed by the wounds they inflicted on the Crucified” (1996: 30) creates “an asymmetrical dialectic” between the divine grace and divine justice (Volf, 1996: 29). What this means is that “even if the

will to embrace is indiscriminate, the *embrace* itself is conditional” (Volf, 1996: 29). In other words, the “eschatological confrontation” of the cross, to use Koyama’s words, really leads to eternal punishment.<sup>16</sup> But this is also precisely why the death of Christ as penal and substitutionary is truly such good news.

According to Wolfhart Pannenberg, Luther was likely the first since the apostle Paul to apprehend the death of Christ as vicarious penal suffering (1968: 279). Pannenberg might well be right, for Luther in his commentary on Galatians 3:13 makes this exuberant oration of how Christ bore fully the divine punishment for human sin:

[O]ur most merciful Father, seeing us to be oppressed and overwhelmed with the curse of the law, and so to be holden [*sic*] under the same, that we could never be delivered from it of our own power, sent His Only Son into the world, and laid upon Him all the sins of men, saying, be Thou Peter that denier; Paul that persecuter [*sic*], and cruel oppressor; David that adulterer; that sinner who did eat the fruit in Eden; that thief who hanged upon the cross, and briefly, be Thou that person who hath committed the sins of all men: see therefore that thou [*sic*] pay and satisfy for them. Here cometh the law and saith: I find Him a sinner, and such a one as hath taken upon Him the sins of all men, and I see no sins else but in Him: therefore let Him die upon the cross: and so it setteth upon Him and killeth Him. By this means the whole world is purged and cleansed from sin, and so delivered from death and all evils. Now sin being vanquished and death abolished by this one man, God would see nothing else in the whole world, if it did believe it, but a mere cleansing and righteousness. And if any remnants of sin should remain, yet for the great glory that is in Christ, God would not see them. (1979: 167-68)

In sum, because of the nature of the penal-substitutionary death of Christ, no human being needs to fear the threat of eternal damnation. By the mercy of God, sinners do not need to receive what they deserve, for Christ has fully received on himself their due punishment. By the grace of God, not only are sinners acquitted in Christ, they now receive what they do not deserve, namely, the gifts of eternal, abundant life and reconciliation with their Creator God. In other words, the Cross *is* the answer to the problem of eternal damnation. Within the biblical message of judgment there is always the offer of grace. For “[b]y divine grace, the violence that we, as God’s enemies, ought to have suffered, was borne for us by our Savior. The divine hospitality extended to us comes at the cost of divine violence suffered on our behalf” (Chua, 2006b: 24).

What about the eternal destiny of those who, through no fault of their own, die without the gospel? Here, we need to take the path of theological agnosticism. Perhaps Barth can help us here. He suggests that while we must not presume on

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<sup>16</sup> Other than asserting that eternal punishment involves the complete absence of God, it is beyond the scope of this dissertation to debate the nature of hell, especially in relation to the theories of annihilationism and conditionalism. See Erickson (1998: 1242-48) for a helpful discussion and critique on these theories.

God's grace and assume "eternal patience" on his part, we could also be open "to the possibility that in the reality of God and man in Jesus Christ there is contained much more than we might expect and therefore the supremely unexpected withdrawal of that final threat" (Barth, 1961: 477-78). In other words, instead of affirming or denying universal salvation, "we can only hope" in the sovereign compassion of God while not neglecting the work of calling people to repentance in Christ (Barth, 1961: 477). That is quite possibly the theological posture as well adopted by Kitamori and Koyama.

The gospel therefore is not to be preached in negative terms, that is, using the threat of eternal damnation as a means to coerce belief. Such conversion motivated by fear is not likely to last. Rather, the gospel is good news, not bad news. It is the glorious message that God is *for us* (*Deus pro nobis*; cf. Jn. 3:17). The focus of the preaching of the gospel then should be on the demeanor of God's suffering love, and what God has done through the painful death of Christ in order to redeem us from the judgment of sin and death, and reconcile us to himself. For indeed it is true, as Kitamori and Koyama point out – in accordance with Luther and Barth – that God's dealing with humankind is ultimately defined by his love rather than his wrath.

### Methodological Concerns

An important question that arises from this research is the nature of theology, and the attendant problem of theological language. In this section, we will discuss these two issues, paying particular attention to the works of Kitamori and Koyama. Reference is made to Endō from the sidelines since the genre of most of his works fall under literature rather than theology.

#### *The Nature and Modes of Theology*

Kitamori is regarded in Japan as a systematic theologian, even though his work on the pain of God has never quite been accepted as an important idea in the discipline. In the case of Koyama, while it is undeniable that he works within the theological guild, one would be hard-pressed to classify his works under the rubric of systematic theology. As David Ford rightly observes, Koyama's theology

is not concerned to develop lengthy analyses and arguments, it subverts or explodes positions that seem to him [Koyama] too neatly systematic and coherent, and it points in many ways to the complexity, variety, and ambiguity of reality. There are few confident overviews in this theology. Rather there is a constant questioning, ethical, and imaginative engagement with particular issues and situations, and the attempt to open them up to a better understanding and future. The approach is dialogical and practical. It proceeds usually in short bursts and in a staccato style which provokes the reader and creates new perceptions and connections. It is a combination of prophetic and wisdom literature suited to the perplexing, agonizing

and exciting meeting of ancient and modern, Buddhist and Christian, East and West, rich and poor. (1989: 226-27)

Despite the differences between Kitamori and Koyama in their theological orientation and content, it is interesting to note that in contrast with the emphasis on right doctrines about God, which is implicit to the traditional Western understanding of theology as “the queen of sciences”, both men would, in all probability, view theology as an art whose primary function is that of a servant impressing upon the Church and expressing to the world the mysterious ways of God.

First of all, Kitamori is right to insist that theology must be based on divine revelation and not human speculation (1986: 34). The source of divine revelation is the Bible, which Kitamori likens to the walls of a Japanese castle, perfect and dependable (2000: 170). Koyama similarly subscribes to the fundamental importance of the Word of God as the proper basis of all theology (1999: 76).<sup>17</sup> In other words, both men define theological prolegomena by the primacy of the revealed Word of God. Since the Word of God contains mysterious divine realities that God has chosen so graciously to reveal to humankind, theology must hence inculcate within the believer a profound sense of awe and wonder (Kitamori, 1986: 70). Consequently, Koyama regards the Atonement not as a theological problem to be solved but as a mystery to be marveled at (1985: 256).<sup>18</sup> In this regard, Kitamori laments that much of the theology of the Church “has lost its wonder” (Kitamori, 1986).

As with all mystery, divinity cannot be mastered and neatly systematized. The mystery of faith can only be apprehended through thoughtful participation, by reflecting on it and ultimately living it out. Here, we see the positive contribution that the Japanese cultural disposition can make to the theological enterprise, for it lends to the formation of thought forms which are more amenable to intuitive comprehension rather than to the organization of dogmatic details. It is hardly surprising that the writings of Kitamori and Koyama are commonly characterized by linguistic elements relating to the aesthetic, the intuitive, and the emotional – the primacy of which traits is often stressed in Japanese culture (cf. Nakamura, 1964: 551-57; Spae, 1971: 171-206).

The literary nature of the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama indeed confirms Frederick Ferre’s observation that theological discourse is

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<sup>17</sup> Koyama understands the Word of God not as a static entity divorced from historical reality, but as the prophetic divine Word illumined and enlivened by the Holy Spirit in a specific socio-historical context (1999: 76-77; cf. John 14:26).

<sup>18</sup> The French philosopher Gabriel Marcel makes the classic distinction between a problem and a mystery. A problem is one that seeks a solution, while a mystery calls for different levels of understanding. See Marcel, *The Mystery of Being: 1. Reflection and Mystery* (Chicago: Henry Regnery, 1950), pp. 197-219. I am indebted to Dr. Kevin Vanhoozer for directing me to Marcel. See also Gallagher (1962: 30-49) for a discussion on Marcel’s distinction.

multifunctional, hence multimodal (1961: 93). Each type of theological speech carries with it specific and distinguishing linguistic features. Broadly speaking, theological language can be divided into two kinds: statements *about* religion and statements *in* religion. The first type is largely conceptual and propositional in form, and it is the linguistic vehicle for the study and understanding of religion. The study of systematic theology would utilize language of this sort. The second type is predominantly expressive and symbolic in form, its main terms being images, and its function being the direct expression of personal religious expression. Here, language is used to experience and express a spiritual sense of wonder. It does seem evident that Japanese theological writings fall under the latter category.

### *Paradox as a Theological Device*

From the writings of Kitamori and Koyama, we see the turn to the aesthetic as one of the principal means to recover or maintain the sense of wonder when reflecting on divine realities. For them, theological aestheticism is expressed primarily through the device of the paradox. Indeed, their writings are fraught with dialectical tensions. However, unlike the dialectical theology of the neo-orthodox theologians which propositionalizes the relationship between thesis and antithesis by holding them together in tandem, Kitamori and Koyama seem to focus on the antithesis, or the “lesser idea,” thereby straining the effect of the paradox. For instance, while traditional doctrine may simply explain the Incarnation as God becoming human, Kitamori and Koyama would emphasize the distinctive message of the Incarnation as revealing the “smallness” of God in contrast to the common idea of the greatness of God. Hence, we see, for example, Kitamori’s particular accent placed on the pain of God. Koyama, of course, revels in the divine paradox that the omnipotent, omnipresent, and omniscient God who creates the universe is indeed the God who walks at the speed of three miles an hour, constantly moves toward the periphery in search of the one lost sheep, embraces impassionedly with his crucified mind, and who gives of himself in suffering for the redemption of others. To the Japanese mind, there is an austere beauty to these ideas.

The ready acceptance of paradox on the part of Kitamori and Koyama is certainly reflective of their Japanese cultural sensibilities, and this seems to move them away from the propositional theologizing that is so highly valued in the Western academy.<sup>19</sup> Their works, in contrast to Western theological writings, clearly conform to the Eastern tradition of wisdom where truth is often – and more powerfully – conveyed through paradox than through proposition.

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<sup>19</sup> The linguistic fact that in the Japanese language, the same word is used for paradox and contradiction, namely, *mujun* 矛盾, for example, hints at the Japanese difficulty of systematizing ideas in a rational and logical fashion.

The use of the paradox as a methodological device is one that Kitamori intentionally and repeatedly uses in his theologizing (2000: 162). For instance, he insists that the meaning of Immanuel in Matthew 1:23-25 cannot be fully understood except in its paradoxical relationship with the meaning of Christ's cry of dereliction from the cross in Matthew 27:45 (Kitamori, 2000: 7-21). In this case, the paradox, or the "wondrous truth" (*zetsumyō no shinr* 絶妙の真理) as Kitamori calls it, is that our experience of "God with us" is made possible by his desertion of Immanuel on the cross. Here is another example. In order to avoid theological distortion, says Kitamori, the Parable of Workers in the Vineyard (Mt. 20:1-16) must be read in tandem with the Parable of the Talents (Mt. 25:14-30) (2000: 155-63). The paradox here is the relationship between grace and responsibility. Takenaka Masao applies the same technique when he employs the aesthetic motif of *wabi* 侘び in his presentation on the life of Christ, "the Son of the living God" – a life characterized, paradoxically, by the *wabi* of solitariness, poverty, simplicity, emptiness, and humility (1986: 78-82).

By all accounts, the supreme divine paradox is the death of Christ. We have already seen how Kitamori and Koyama expound on this through the respective motifs of the pain of God and the crucified mind. The paradox of the death of the God-man in Christ on the cross for the salvation of humankind is shared by Lee, for whom "the meaning of the Cross as the depth of divine empathy implies paradoxically the unconditional penetration of divine love into the ultimate negativities of human existence" (1974: 58). It is an unfathomable mystery that we should "die with [Christ's] death to sin and live with His resurrection to God" (Lee, 1974: 58).

### *The Problem of Theological Language*

The tendency toward the intuitive rather than the rational in the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama is due in part to the fact that Japanese linguistic forms "are more oriented to sensitive and emotive nuances than directed toward logical exactness" (Nakamura, 1964: 531).<sup>20</sup> Here, we see the intrinsic and intricate relationship between culture and language. Indeed, the intuitive

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<sup>20</sup> When I was Dr. J. I. Packer's teaching assistant at Regent College, I always found great difficulty grading the examination essays of many international students from East Asia. One day, an elderly Japanese pastor, who was then taking a sabbatical year at Regent, came up to me after the systematic theology finals and said, "We Japanese are very bad in systematic theology. We don't think like that." This example is, of course, purely anecdotal, and it would be absolutely wrong to conclude that Japanese people do not think logically. The international reputation of Japanese students in the mathematical sciences attests to their ability in the use of rigorous analytical logic. The point maintained here is the "non-rationalistic tendencies" that Japanese people display when it comes to the existential issues of life and faith (Nakamura, 1964: 531). (Note that "non-rationalistic" does not mean "irrational.") One reason for this is that the Japanese language does not facilitate precise, careful definitions when it comes to matters of the heart.

orientation of the Japanese mind is often mirrored in the language, and it is not uncommon to hear Westerners complaining about the vagueness of Japanese linguistic expressions. We note, for instance, that Kitamori's use of the word *itami* 痛み (pain) is very broad and not always consistent, referring at various times to Christ's passion, divine sorrow as a result of human sin, and the conflict between divine love and divine wrath. Also, the distinction he makes between *jittai* 実体 (substance) and *honshitsu* 本質 (essence) is logically murky, and leaves unanswered the nagging question as to whether he understands the pain of God as a divine ontology of substance or of relation? Kitamori is obviously unperturbed by the problem, if he ever thought that there was one.

The nature of the theological impasse for the English reader in this case is both semantic and cognitive. The point to be borne in mind is that there is no exact conceptual equivalence between Japanese and English – or for that matter, any two languages – and this has to do with the relationship between language and thought. Subsequent research following the pioneering work of American linguist Edward Sapir and his student Benjamin Lee Whorf in the 1930s has shown that language does exert a substantial – although not total – influence in predisposing speakers of that language toward adopting a particular way of thinking.<sup>21</sup>

The relationship between language and thought bears profound implications for the theological task. With regard to this, the perception on the part of the non-Western Church of the imperialism of Western theology purveyed through the linguistic juggernaut of English cannot be summarily dismissed. Along with the current movement of the center of gravity of the Church to the southern hemisphere comes the growing inevitable reality of a preferred option for the vernacular in the apprehension of biblical revelation (cf. Sanneh, 1989; Bediako, 1995; Walls, 1996; Jenkins, 2002; Phan, 2003). This will have significant repercussions on the theology of the Church in view of the growth of world Christianity. Indeed, the first Pentecost on which people gathered from different nations and praised God *together* in their respective languages, hence signaling a reversal of the Tower of Babel, is now interpreted to provide fresh motivation for what Harold Netland calls “globalizing theology” (2006: 30).<sup>22</sup> Interestingly, the Pentecostal reversal of Babel is not total in that there was never a divine impulse

<sup>21</sup> For an excellent summary of the Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis, see Trudgill (1983: 24-27). See also Whorf (2001: 363-81) on his work among the Hopi Indians showing how their interpretation of experience is directly affected by the structure of the Hopi language.

<sup>22</sup> Netland provides a “preliminary definition” of globalizing theology as “theological reflection rooted in God’s self-revelation in Scripture and informed by the historical legacy of the Christian community through the ages, the current realities of the world, and the diverse perspectives of Christian communities throughout the world, with a view to greater holiness in living and faithfulness in fulfilling God’s mission in all the world through the church” (2006: 30).

toward a common language; rather it confers theological and missiological justification on the vernacular principle (cf. Rev. 5:9; 7:9).

For a long time now, non-Western Christians who want to study theology in the academy need to learn the European languages. Many of these students, ironically, experience the cognitive constraints imposed by the Western languages such that it becomes difficult for them to theologize in their original contexts.<sup>23</sup> There must come a time – if it has not already come – for Western theologians to take up the challenge of learning non-Western languages so that they can pay closer attention both to *how* non-Western Christians do theology and to *what* they are saying. In the words of Kenyan theologian John Mbiti, “[W]e have eaten theology with you [...] will you eat theology with us?” (cited in Bediako, 1995: 167). Theological idioms from another culture can only enrich one’s own understanding of faith. Conversely, the Church can only become theologically impoverished if the barrier of language is allowed to maintain the mutually-indifferent bifurcation between Western theology and non-Western theology.

There is another problem relating to theological language – a philosophical one. Originally, the debate was about the possibility of using language to talk about God, but the concern has now moved to the meaning and meaningfulness of God-talk, as it is called.<sup>24</sup> The possibility of God-talk is predicated on two factors, one linguistic and the other theological. First, the symbolic nature of human language makes it possible *in some way* to talk about God and matters of ultimate concern (see Chua, 2007).<sup>25</sup> Besides this linguistic fact, there is the

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<sup>23</sup> This is another instance of the Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis. Koyama is, of course, a fine exception. He circumvents the problem of linguistic constraint by creating new words and expressions (e.g. “neighborology,” “the peripherized Christ, etc.).

<sup>24</sup> See William Alston, *Divine Nature and Human Language: Essays in Philosophical Theology* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1989) for a sustained discussion on the subject from the perspective of modern analytical philosophy. I am indebted to Harold Netland for this reference.

<sup>25</sup> Language as a uniquely human phenomenon is distinguished by three properties: arbitrariness, displacement, and creativity. By arbitrariness is meant the absence of a necessary relation between a linguistic form and the meaning it carries. For example, other than conventional agreement, there is no compelling reason why English speakers should call a canine animal *dog*, rather than, say, *kog*. Next, displacement allows language users to symbolize objects, events and concepts which are not immediately present in time and space. Thus, we can talk about things outside our immediate environment or even things that have only an imaginary existence. Displacement enables humans to handle generalizations and abstractions, and manipulate concepts such as truth, infinity, multiplication, etc. Third, creativity, or productivity, is evidenced by the fact that human speakers can, without conscious effort, generate and understand an infinite number of grammatically well-formed utterances from a finite set of linguistic symbols. This is why there are word dictionaries but not sentence dictionaries. In the realm of human cognitive endeavour, linguistic creativity enables humans to bridge the common and the extraordinary, the familiar and the extremely unfamiliar. For example, although there are no ready-made words for all the discoveries and inventions

theological assertion that God always speaks in human terms – through his word and through the historical event of the Incarnation (so Irenaeus; cf. Behr, 2000: 89-90). However, any discourse about God must respect his uniqueness and mystery. There indeed exists a linguistic form of divine transcendence which necessitates “speaking at the edges of language and straining its limits” (van Buren, 1972: 115). The implication then is that *all* language about God is in some sense metaphorical (cf. Boersma, 2003: 33).<sup>26</sup> In other words, although as humans we cannot comprehend the essence of God, divine revelation is such that we use trust human language to speak properly about God (Boersma, 2005: 4). Through the Thomist device of analogical predication, circumscribed by biblical revelation, divine realities can be described by reflecting on human experience.

The Bible certainly speaks of God acting and feeling like a human being. Therefore, the objection voiced by proponents of divine impassibility against the use of linguistic expressions such as “the pain of God” and “divine pathos” on the grounds that such language is purely anthropomorphic or anthropopathic is, of course, rhetorical, since descriptions of divine impassibility are *also* couched in anthropomorphic or anthropopathic language, albeit negatively (e.g. Num. 23:19). In a similar vein, Boersma points out the inconsistency of people who understand God’s wrath metaphorically while applying a literal interpretation to his love (2003: 33). In conjunction with this, Boersma also warns against the common fallacy that metaphors are “somehow less real” because they are perceived as “*just* metaphors” (Boersma, 2003: 33, emphasis in text). Quoting the late Colin Gunton, Boersma insists that the contrary is true, that metaphors plumb the depth of reality by facilitating “a new way of thinking about and living in the world” (Gunton, 1989: 51-52, cited in Boersma, 2003: 33). The various metaphors in the New Testament describing the death of Christ, for example, are precisely employed in order to show the *reality* of the Atonement. The Church’s understanding of the death of Christ becomes amplified.

This, of course, does not grant us the license to impose our cultural categories onto God uncritically and unilaterally. As Boersma cogently points out, “[W]e cannot simply exchange [metaphors] for others without also affecting the contents of what we are saying. *We need to ask what is lost in the shift from one metaphor or model to another*” (Boersma, 2003: 33, emphasis added). In other words, if a new metaphor compromises or excludes the existing meaning conveyed by other biblical metaphors rather than enlarging it, then that is a good indication that it is an unsuitable metaphor. Using this test to evaluate the

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of cyber technology, we are able to use the linguistic resources at our disposal in novel ways, and we do so successfully. The linguistic properties of arbitrariness, displacement and creativity are intrinsically tied up with the symbolic nature of language. See Chua 2007.

<sup>26</sup> This, of course, begs the question on the meaning of “metaphorical” and “literal,” or of “analogical” and “univocal.” See Alston (1989: 39-63) for a helpful discussion on this vexing issue.

plethora of metaphors in the writings of Kitamori and Koyama, one can safely say that they enrich biblical revelation rather than detract from it. On the other hand, Endō's metaphor of the maternal God is not a good metaphor if it insists on the exclusion of God's paternal characteristics. In any case, the point is well taken that theologians need to constantly wrestle with the nature and limits of God-talk so as to check the ever-lurking danger of humans creating God through their culturally-formed and embedded images.

### **The Place of Western Theology in Contextualization**

The cause of Christ would be gravely jeopardized if in the name of the vernacular principle, Western theology and non-Western theology are pitted against each other. On this matter, Kitamori and Koyama offer some helpful thoughts. First, we need to acknowledge "[t]he impressive quality and scope of Western scholarship in all areas of theological studies" (Koyama, 1993e: 90). There are historical reasons for this, and they are not accidental. Theological education throughout the world is therefore, in a real sense, indebted to Western theological achievements (Koyama, 1993e: 90). It would be wrong to reject Western theology outright, not only on philosophical grounds but also for practical reasons.

[I]t is simplistic to call for the complete elimination of the influence of Western theological thought, for instance, from Asia. It would require the resignation of nearly all theological professors and church leaders from their positions. Nearly all books on every shelf of the theological libraries throughout Asia would be declared worthless. (Koyama, 1993e: 93)

Instead of mutual antagonism, Koyama advocates a posture of "mutual correction" between Western theology and indigenous theologies (Koyama, 1993e: 94). While non-Western Christians should continue to be open to learn from the West, Western Christians should exercise humility to seriously listen to and learn from the rest of the world as well.<sup>27</sup> As Clifford Geertz would say, "Monologues are of little value here" (1973: 29). Geertz' comment, though made in an entirely different context, is totally applicable to theological reflection and missiological practice. This point has already been belabored above.<sup>28</sup> One needs to note, of course, that theological division is not a problem that exists solely between the West and the non-West; it will indeed become an increasing challenge even between non-Western cultures as "new centres of

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<sup>27</sup> At the moment, many Western theology textbooks simply relegate non-Western theologians to a line or two in the footnotes, hence not presenting an accurate picture of them. For example, Erickson's magisterial work contains a single reference to Kitamori in a footnote (1998: 295 n), and a one-liner on Koyama (Erickson, 1998: 80).

<sup>28</sup> This dissertation hopes to set a good example of what cross-cultural theological interaction could look like.

Christianity's universality" sprout all over the world (Mbiti, cited in Bediako, 1995: 163). Koyama's call for an attitude of openness and humility is relevant for all instances. In sum, cross-cultural or globalizing theologizing is best done not by confrontation between the different contexts, nor by mutual indifference, but through respectful conversation.

Kitamori offers a similar, but slightly nuanced, take on the issue of Western theology. First and foremost, he asserts that theology must seek to be concretely universal even though it must be mediated by the particular (2005: 7-8). Indeed, he acknowledges that much of the orthodox dogma of the Church that had historically grown out of Greek theology could claim universal validity despite the particularity of Greek thought (Kitamori, 2005: 8). Theologizing today from the Japanese perspective – for that matter, any cultural perspective – involves a tension between two poles. On the one hand, Kitamori sees the need for Japanese theology to be freed from what Harvie Conn calls a "Constantinian cultural captivity" (1978: 41); on the other, given the long and venerable tradition of Western theology, he believes that any non-Western theology must necessarily be mediated through the established entity of Western theology as it seeks to approach the Bible from a fresh point of view and renew the tradition of orthodox Western dogma (Kitamori, 1978: 8). Kitamori's approach certainly brings to mind the "indigenizing principle" and the "pilgrim principle" that Andrew Walls posits to prevent contextual theology from becoming either syncretistic or provincial (1996: 7-9). Kitamori is exemplary in this regard. Unashamedly Lutheran by confession, he exercises great facility in interacting with Western thought as well as with Japanese cultural ideas. Although he writes in Japanese, he constructs his theology with the welfare of the whole Church in mind.

### **Distinctives of an Evangelical Approach to Cross-Cultural Theologizing**

In an interesting article entitled, "Is 'Japanese Theology' Possible?" (1969), Kitamori explores the tension between cultural relevance and syncretism in the discussion on indigenization. Rather than pitting "theology from above" against "theology from below," Kitamori advocates a third way of doing theology, namely, "from above *to below*" (Kitamori, 1969: 81, emphasis in text). The universal gospel has to be particularized in context. Kitamori elaborates, "Universality which is not mediated through particularities is a mere result of imagination and it does not exist anywhere in reality" (Kitamori, 1969: 83).

In a similar vein, Stephen Bevans states in the opening line of his book *Models of Contextual Theology* that "[t]here is no such thing as 'theology'; there is only *contextual* theology" (2002: 3, emphasis in text). The fact that biblical revelation – in both the Old and the New Testament – is given to humankind in concrete socio-cultural contexts implies that the subsequent task of theology cannot be anything less than "an attempt to understand Christian faith in terms of a particular context" (Bevans, 2002: 3). Indeed, the cultural contextualization of

theology is not only a missiological possibility, but a “theological imperative” (Bevans, 2002: 3). In this final section of the chapter, we draw from our research on Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama, and propose three distinctives that can serve as parameters for an evangelical approach to doing theology in a cross-cultural context.

### The Incarnation as Theological Model

Koyama suggests rightly that the first requirement for doing theology is not reason, but faith, that is, “a total personal commitment” to the revelation of God (1975a: 52). Such faith leads to an understanding of the supreme revelation of God through the incarnation of Jesus Christ in history as the locus of what Koyama calls “authentic contextualization” (1999: 15). For the Incarnation is not only a historical event, but a theological one in that it mediates God’s self-disclosure under culture-specific conditions (Koyama, 1999: 17). In other words, Christ did not simply become human: he became a *particular* person “in a particular locality and in a particular ethnic group, at a particular place and time” (Walls, 1996: 27). Walls develops further the idea of the Incarnation as “translation”:

Christ can become visible within the very things which constitute nationality. The first divine act of translation into humanity thus gives rise to a constant succession of new translations. Christian diversity is the necessary product of the Incarnation. (1996: 27-28)

In sum, theological contextualization is possible because of the Incarnation which affirms the “infinite translatability of the Christian faith” (Walls, 1996: 22). Biblical revelation can indeed be contextualized and embedded in any culture. Besides providing a philosophical basis for the possibility of theology, Koyama also sees the Incarnation, through the example of suffering of the incarnated Christ, as constituting a practical model for living as well as for doing theology. Koyama recalls Luther’s famous words to substantiate his point, “Not reading books or speculating but living, dying and being damned make a theologian” (Walls, 1996: 22).

Using the kenotic example of Christ, Koyama believes that theology must be done with a “self-emptying” attitude (1974b: viii). Minimally, this means that the language of certainty and superiority must give way to the language of self-denial and interrelatedness.

Superiority is a cultural concept. To say that Christianity is superior to Buddhism, or vice versa, is empty talk. The Gospel is not called to be superior. It calls us to bear “good fruits” (Mt. 7:17). The “no other name” theology (Act. 4:12) signifies an exclusiveness whose character is “full of grace and truth” (Jn. 1:14). Unlike the ordinary cultural concept of exclusiveness, this Christological exclusiveness, drawing its life from love of unfathomable depth (1 Cor. 13:13), goes far beyond

any comparative discussion of superiority or inferiority of religions. (Koyama, 1997b: 58)

### Epistemic Humility as Theological Virtue

Koyama goes even further than saying that theology has to be incarnate: it has to be crucified just as Jesus was crucified. He then asserts, “It is the crucified mind that can meaningfully participate in authentic contextualization” (1999: 18).

[The crucified mind] is accommodational and prophetic. It knows that only by the grace of God can it be, and remain, accommodational and prophetic at all [...]. The mission of the church begins with the nurture of the crucified mind, the mind of Christ in the context of theological raw situations. (Koyama, 1999: 18)

Doing theology with a crucified mind implies first and foremost cultivating an attitude of humility. True theological insights are by nature “*humble* theological insights,” for “[t]hey are *servants*, not masters, to the ‘inexpressible gift’ of God in Christ (2 Cor. 9:15)” (Koyama, 1999: 142, emphases in text). Indeed, all theologies are but “*humble* theological attempts to express some fragment of the fullness of God’s glory in Christ (Isa. 6:1-8);” even put together, they “cannot exhaust and prove the depth of God’s purpose in Christ (Rom. 11:33-35)” (Koyama, 1999: 142, emphasis in text). For this reason, Koyama is extremely critical of the theological structure of denominationalism which he lambastes as “sick,” “deadly,” and “demonic” (Koyama, 1999: 143). For denominationalism causes “humble theological insights to be puffed up” and seeks “[to] monopolize Christ theologically” (Koyama, 1999: 143).<sup>29</sup> In the final analysis, in casting aside the crucified mind of Christ, denominationalism betrays faith, for it turns from its total commitment to divine revelation to a relentless quest for power and control (cf. Koyama, 1975a: 52). In a word, without putting on the crucified mind, theology can only become “the force for ‘tearing apart’ and ‘rending’” rather than what it is supposed to be: a healing balm for a suffering world (Koyama, 1999: 143).

Koyama’s emphasis on humility is echoed by Hans Boersma. Responding to Richard Neuhaus’ comment that “all theories of atonement are but probings into mystery, the mystery of a love that did not have to be but was, and is,” Boersma issues a call to all theologians to exercise “epistemic humility” in their work, because “love cannot, in the final analysis, be grasped and explained” (2004: 13). This, of course, does not mean abdicating all theological responsibility and

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<sup>29</sup> It is important to note the vital distinction that Koyama makes between denomination and denominationalism. Denominations are “valuable products of the history of the Christian church [with] serious *theological* beginnings” (Koyama, 1999: 141). Denominationalism happens when non-theological factors – often relating to power and money – hijack and essentialize the theological understanding of denomination (Koyama, 1999: 143).

surrendering the use of reason. What it means is the acknowledgement that when it comes to divine realities, our understanding can only be partial even if it is clear.<sup>30</sup> The opposite attitude is “epistemic arrogance,” the insistence that there is such a thing as “the pure theology” which represents the whole truth and only the truth, and the consequent condemnation of every idea that does not conform to it. Koyama finds the idea of pure theology repulsive and perceives that it contains in it “more danger to human welfare [...] than in syncretism” (1993c: 228). Such theology is ideological, because “it loses the dimension of the strange paradox and makes a claim that it is at the center, thus pushing aside the living God” (Koyama, 1985: 100). The result is theological imperialism which, in its idolatrous confusion between Christological uniqueness and ideational exclusivism, does not tolerate contextualization of any sort. The threat is more often than not an insidious one, and missionaries, especially theological educators in another culture, therefore need to be constantly self-critical of their theological assumptions and posture. In missionary practice then, while we must not lose our message, we must also not lose our manners (Robert Solomon, personal communication). Dean Gilliland’s wise words are instructive, “Contextualization is, ultimately, a matter of attitude, translated into ministry” (1989: 28).

### Canonicity and Catholicity as Theological Principles

Granted that no one has monopoly on theological truth, how then does one guard against interpretive relativism? This question is especially crucial to evangelicals, defined by their commitment to the Bible as the inspired and authoritative Word of God. The answer is twofold: recognizing that the Bible is “overdetermined in meaning” (Vanhoozer, 1999: 27), and understanding the Church, the Body of Christ – historically and globally – as the ultimate hermeneutical community. The former means that divine revelation is much larger and richer than the capacity of any finite culture to contain it. Steve Strauss has rightly observed that every context will increase awareness of some aspects of the biblical text while *at the same time* decreasing awareness of other aspects of the text (2006: 110-113). Even though there is a single meaning in the biblical text, it is such an “abundant” meaning that multiple insights from different individuals and cultures are needed *together* in order to explicate it fully. Vanhoozer suggests that “[t]he single correct meaning may only come to light through multicultural interpretation” (1999: 27). Koyama is therefore correct in his assertion that there can be no private theology (1999: 77). Criteria for theological assessment must be drawn from two sources: the biblical canon and the global ecclesiastical community. In sum, all theological construction

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<sup>30</sup> This is indeed the presupposition behind the critical realist epistemology, “that the world is orderly and that that order can be apprehended, *in some measure*, by human reason” (Hiebert, 1999: 71, emphasis added).

must pass the rigorous tests of canonicity and catholicity (see Vanhoozer, 2005: 115-237; 2006: 62-64; Chua, 2007).

### Conclusion

The works of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama certainly provide us with rich fodder for reflection, not only on the meaning of the Cross but also on the nature of theology. Although Endō departs considerably from the Bible by focusing only on divine love and ignoring divine judgment altogether, he helps us understand Japanese proclivities for abiding companionship and an embracing inclusiveness, and challenges us to think more deeply and creatively about the nature of the divine confrontation that Christ experienced on behalf of humankind on the cross. Concerning the relationship between divine love and divine wrath – or between divine embrace and divine confrontation – Kitamori’s motif of divine pain and Koyama’s reflections on the crucified mind of the suffering God can prove missiologically useful in redirecting our attention from the mystery of eternal damnation to the divine demeanor of impassioned love and abject humiliation displayed on the cross for the sake of sinful and suffering humanity.

As we have seen in this chapter, the writings of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama have raised numerous questions regarding theological methodology. Minimally, it calls into question whether it is necessary for theology to be predicated on a *particular* method or framework. Who then gets to set the criteria for “right” methodology? Is it legitimate to think of the possibility of theology being expressed in different culturally-conditioned modes? What about the use of literature as a theological medium? In relation to this last question, one may consider the theological intent and implications of Endō’s religiously-motivated novels. What is the difference between, say, Endō’s *Silence* and John Bunyan’s *The Pilgrim’s Progress*? These are important questions. Obviously, they are beyond the scope of this present work, but suffice it to say, for our purposes, that Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama have shown us that theology as an activity of reflecting on the mystery of God as revealed through his Word, through history, and ultimately through the Incarnation of Jesus Christ, is truly a multifaceted discipline. These Japanese Christians have reminded us that there are paradoxical and parabolic modes of doing theology, that truths about God are not only cognitive but also affective, and that they can therefore be presented in a creative and aesthetic manner.

Indeed, theology begins with wonder, but it also should end with it. In the words of J. I. Packer, “theology must always lead to doxology” (personal communication). It is truly my experience that this study on the death of Christ from the perspectives of Kitamori, Endō, and Koyama has certainly led me to a deeper and more profound appreciation of the wondrous mystery of God’s suffering love and his saving work for the sake of the world. For on the cross, the

Son of God not only suffered because of sinful humanity, he suffered like sinful humanity; and most of all, he died for sinful humanity.

